passageway flanked by the Tibetan highlands on one side and the Mongolian plateau on the other. This strategic corridor was frequently targeted by marauding tribes from the Central Asian steppes. The Chinese dealt with this constant threat through a mixture of coercive military campaigns and diplomacy, which included marriage alliances, delivery of tribute, grant of high office and honours, and what one Chinese general of the Han dynasty, Ban Chao, described as a strategy of ‘using the barbarians to attack the barbarians’. [1] For example, in 648 CE , the Tang attacked the Central Asian kingdom of Kucha supported by a cavalry composed of the eastern Turks and the Tiele tribe from Mongolia.

This history of having to cope with constant attacks by hostile tribes, which were regarded as inferior and less civilized in comparison to themselves, gave rise to the Chinese Middle Kingdom complex, a sense of superiority over these ethnicities on the periphery. This sense persisted even when the Han heartland fell under the sway of foreign entities such as the Mongols and the Manchus. In some cases, these tribes themselves became Sinicized and, in turn, assumed the attitudes and mores of the heartland Chinese. The homogeneity of the latter-day Han Chinese is more a cultural rather than ethnic homogeneity, reinforced by shared attitudes and a unified script. The sense of siege from a hostile periphery persists today in relation to Tibet and Xinjiang and, to an extent, Inner Mongolia, despite their having been assimilated politically.

China was thus conceived of by itself as a civilized centre with concentric zones of progressively less civilized barbarian states that had to acknowledge the centrality and superiority of the Middle Kingdom. This hierarchy had to be maintained through elaborate rituals and diplomacy, but also by the use of force if necessary. The empire could and did expand through the incorporation of the periphery or parts thereof, but this would entail over time the need to enforce homogeneity over the new areas so that they graduated to being part of the core. Plurality could only be tolerated as a temporary condition.

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